Finding the Guard (v0.0.1)[1]

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The guard is the fencer's foundation. Ridolfo Capo Ferro describes the guard as the alphabet of the art of fencing. TK. It is also one of the most characteristic elements of many rapier styles—Fabris, Capo Ferro, and Thibault are all recognisable from the posture alone. Nevertheless, I find it to be one of the most difficult things to teach. What follows is partly an exploration of guards from various Italian sources, partly an attempt to turn those into coaching cues (see *Cues and Details* in the full collection).

1. Principles

It seems to me that a guard needs to accomplish TK things:

- provide a flexible starting point for attack and defence.
- be stable, but mobile
- minimise an opponent's possible lines of attack, and thereby reduce the possibilities that a fencer needs to account for.

2. Primary Source Guards

I have included examples from three treatises: Capo Ferro Ridolfo Capo Ferro's *Gran Simulacro*, Saviolo's *His Practice*, and Fabris Salvator's *Scienza d'Arme*. These are examples of three very different postures: Saviolo is relatively upright, Capo Ferro leans back and Fabris is bent over forward. All three, however, address the same TK: mobility, TK, and limiting the opponent's options.

[1] This document is part of a collection of texts on Italian rapier fencing, and may reference parts that are not included here. The current version of the full collection can be found on https://github.com/laugedideriksen/ItalianRapier.

2.1. Capo Ferro



Figure 1: Capo Ferro's guard

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/4/40/Capo_Ferro_06.png

2.2. Saviolo: *His Practice* (1595)

In *His Practice* (1595), Vincentio Saviolo describes three guards ('wards') for single rapier. Although he writes that all three are useful in practice, he also emphasises the didactic quality of the first two: the first ward teaches nimbleness, judgement, and coordination; the second ward teaches the stoccata, the imbroccata, and the use of the empty hand. (See also *Empty Hand Basics* in the full collection).

According to Saviolo the guard must 'frame your hand, your foote, and your body, all which partes must goe together, and unlesse you can stirre and move all these together, you shall never be able to performe any great matter, but with great danger' (Saviolo 1595, 8).

First Ward

Describing his first ward 'breeds a judgement of the time, and a readinesse and nimblenesse as well of the hand as the foote, together with the body: and from this you come prepared to learne other wards with more facilitie, and to have a greater insight and understanding in many things' (Saviolo 1595, 16) (Figure 2). On his account, 'many Nations use this ward in fight verie much, especially with the single rapier, both Italians, French-men, Spaniards, & Almanes' (Saviolo 1595, 16).

> [The scholler must] stand with his right foote formost, with his knee somewhat bowing, but that his body rest more upon the lefte legge, not stedfast and firme as some stand, which seeme to be nayled to the place, but with a readines and nimblenes, as though he were to perform

some feate of activitie … his [weapon] hand be free and at libertie from his body, and that the ward of his hand be directlye against his right knee … [and] the pobnt (*sic*) be directly against the face of his [opponent].

— Saviolo (1595, 8–9)



Figure 2: Saviolo's first ward

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/archive/4/40/20130915232741%21Saviolo_1.jpg

Second Ward

Second, it starts from his 'second ward' which he describes as follows, somewhat contrary to the accompanying illustration (Figure 3):

[The scholler must] place his right legge formoste, a little bending the knee, so that the heele of his right foote stand just against the midst of his left foote, holding his swoord hand close on the outside of his right knee, with his swoorde helde in shorte, least his adversarye should gaine the same, ever keeping the poynte directlye on the face or bellye of his enemye

— Saviolo (1595, 17)



Figure 3: Saviolo's second ward.

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/archive/3/3b/20130915232754%21Saviolo_2.jpg

Third Ward

In contrast to the previous two wards, the description of the third ward (Figure 4) is rather vague. First, he writes:

> … this third warde, which notwithstanding is quite contrarie to the other two. Because that in this you must stand with your feet even together, as if you were readie to sit down, and your rapier hand must bee within your knee, and your point against the face of your enemie
>
> — Saviolo (1595, 19)

And a few pages later:

> When you perfectlie understand your weapons, it maie serve you otherwise, so that you hold not your swoord hand within your knee, for if you finde your enemie to beare his swoord long, being in distance, you maie sodenlie beat it aside with your swoord
>
> — Saviolo (1595, 22)

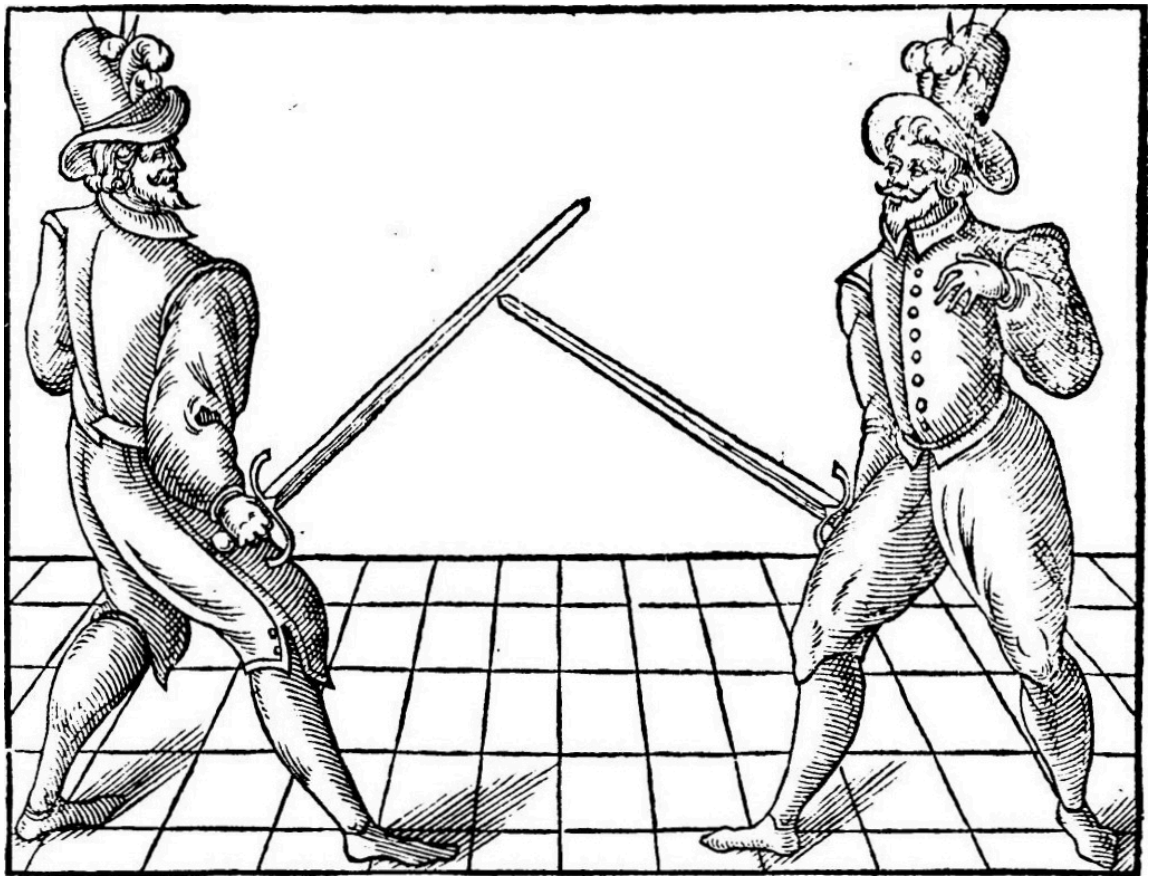


Figure 4: Saviolo's third ward

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/archive/4/40/20130915232805%21Saviolo_3.jpg

2.3. Fabris

Fabris' guards are in many way the opposite of Capo Ferro's. It is also a style with which I have very little experience, and so in no way should what I write here be taken as gospel.

3. Summary

TK. The most obvious conclusion is that there are many ways to skin the poor, proverbial cat. Looking closer at each of the treatises, it becomes clear that within each system several guards not only exist, but are necessary. TK. Thinking of them and practising them as 'ready positions' is didactically useful, but eventually a fencer must learn to also think of them as postures one may pass through in the course of an exchange.

References

Capo Ferro, Ridolfo. n.d. 'Ridolfo Capo Ferro Da Cagli'. Translated by William Wilson and W. Jherek Swanger. Accessed 10 June 2024. https://wiktenauer.com/wiki/Ridolfo_Capo_Ferro_da_Cagli.

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Saviolo, Vincentio. 1595. *His Practise. In Two Bookes. The First Intreating of the Use of the Rapier and Dagger. The Second, Of Honor and Honorable Quarrels*. London.